

This document provides staff at Nottinghamshire County Council with guidance on Personal health budgets for the NHS funded carers' breaks service. Personal Health Budgets for NHS funded carers' breaks are available via a Managed Service or Direct Payment by NHS Nottingham and Nottinghamshire Clinical Commissioning Group (CCG).

1. Background

Management of the NHS Funded Carers Breaks service has been managed by Rushcliffe CCG from 1 July 2015, on behalf of all the CCG's which are now currently part of the Nottinghamshire ICS (except Bassetlaw and Nottingham City). Since the creation of NHS Nottingham and Nottinghamshire CCG in 2019, this function has been transferred over to the new organisation.

This guidance outlines the current provision available to eligible carers and the criteria to access the support.

2. The Service

The CCG provides a joint source of funding to support carers in taking a short break from their caring role if this has been identified as an outcome in their care and support plan.

A carer's personal health budget can be taken in three ways:

- A managed budget
- A direct payment
- A mixture of both

The total cost of the care must be within the budget allocation.

The process for a managed service is for Nottinghamshire County Council (NCC) to send a referral via email to NHS Nottingham and Nottinghamshire County CCG on ruccg.carersbreaksservice@nhs.net. The referral will be checked against eligibility criteria and, if met, approval is secured by the Lead Nurse of the CCG. Providers i.e. care homes and home care agencies are then advised of invoicing arrangements and these are processed by the CCG.

The carer may also access funding via NCC for a direct payment to commission care from providers of the carer's choice where there is no contract in place. This option offers the carer more choice, control and flexibility over how to use the personal health budget to take a break. The carer can find solutions that may not have been available in the past e.g. to pay for a carer to join them on holiday to provide a break whilst away from home (this funding source is managed by NCC and also available to carers in Bassetlaw).

A carer can choose to take a mixture of both a managed payment and a direct payment so long as the cost of care is within the budget allocation.

3. Personal Health Budget Allocations for Carers Breaks

The amount of funding available for a carer as a personal health budget (PHB) is dependent on the level of need as determined by the NCC carer's assessment.

Carers assessed as having:

- 'High impact' needs can access a PHB of up to £650.
- 'Extremely high impact' needs can access a PHB of up to £1300.

The rationale for these indicative budget allocations are that they relate to the charge for 1 and 2 weeks respite in a NCC Care and Support centre.

The budgets are for use within a 12-month period from the date of the assessment/review. It is anticipated that most carers will not require all of the indicative budget. The amount required will depend on the carers needs for a break as set out in their support plan.

4. Eligibility Criteria

To be eligible for a 'managed service' AND/OR a Direct Payment:

- The carer and cared for must BOTH be registered with a GP Practice within the CCG area (excluding Nottingham City)
- The carer and cared for must BOTH be resident in Nottinghamshire County (except City and Bassetlaw*)
- The carer and cared for must be aged 18 or over
- The carer must have had a NCC Carer's Assessment or review undertaken within the last 12 months of the date of the break
- The carers needs must be defined by the Carer's Assessment or review as having either a high impact or an extremely high impact (as determined by the worker who completed the assessment).

***Bassetlaw is via Direct Payment ONLY and:**

- The carer and/or the cared for must be registered with Bassetlaw CCG. If either the carer or cared for are not registered with Bassetlaw CCG, they must be registered with a GP practice with the Nottingham and Nottinghamshire CCG (excluding Nottingham City)
- The carer and cared for must both be resident in Nottinghamshire County (except City)

5. Defining an NHS Funded Carer's Break

These definitions are applicable to both PHBs managed by NHS Nottingham and Nottinghamshire County CCG and also via direct payments.

A carer's break is:

- A pre-planned break from caring;
- Of primary benefit to the carer e.g. to support them in taking a break from their caring responsibilities such as to take a holiday;
- Likely to be a one-off stay for the cared for in a care home or care agency (including micro providers) to provide support in the cared for's own home or day care;
- 'Short' e.g. a week or two.

A carer's break **isn't**:

- For support in an emergency situation or for crisis prevention;

- For intermittent/fragmented support over a period of weeks/months providing regular ongoing care for the cared for;
- Part of a longer term placement in a care home e.g. for short-term care to trial a placement before a permanent move;
- About accessing the entire potential allocation i.e. the funding allocation is a limit not a 'target'.

6. Referral Information

If the carer has chosen a care provider which has a contract (formerly described as an 'AQP'), NHS Nottingham and Nottinghamshire County CCG will manage the carer's PHB and pay for the care direct. Referrals should be directed to **ruccg.carersbreaksservice@nhs.net** and must fulfil the following requirements:

- The request should be received >5 full working days before the start of the break;
- All referral information should be correctly completed using the form on Mosaic and a case note added;
- It should be sent securely (i.e. via an email address ending in .x.gsi.gov.uk; .gsi.gov.uk; .gse.gov.uk; .gsx.gov.uk; etc. or via Cryptshare);
- No retrospective requests will be accepted;

Referrers are required to inform the service if the break doesn't take place or if there are changes to the break as originally requested.

7. Services for the Cared For

7.1 Planned Short Breaks

If the 'cared for' is eligible for NCC services, planned short breaks can also be commissioned in their name through the NCC. The NCC's Short Breaks Policy provides a matrix to illustrate an indicative personal budget.

The matrix combines the needs of the carer with those of the cared for to indicate a maximum allocation. If planned short breaks are already being accessed through NCC, it is proposed that an NHS funded carers break would only be supported if the indicative budget would not be exceeded when taking into account the funding available through the NHS.

7.2 Continuing Care

If the cared for is eligible for either continuing NHS healthcare or a jointly funded package, then any breaks required for the carer would be commissioned as part of the continuing care package and funded according to the assessed health and social care needs of the cared for. Therefore, those in receipt of continuing healthcare or joint funded packages are not eligible for this scheme.

8. Cost of Care

8.1 Care Home Placements

NCC and Nottingham City Council have agreed standard rates for placements with most of the homes in Nottinghamshire. Every effort should be made to adhere to the Local Authorities' standard rates for NHS funded carers' breaks.

If a home has been identified out of area, similarly, every effort should be made to adhere to that area's Local Authority standard rates.

8.2 Home Care

The CCGs are associate commissioners to NCC's home care contract. Services commissioned from contracted home care providers have associated rates which are also applicable to carers' breaks.

The CCGs may also negotiate rates with non-contracted home care providers i.e. through the continuing care service and these too are applicable to carers' breaks.

9. Direct Payments

A carer can choose a Direct Payment via NCC to commission care from providers of their choice. This gives the carer more choice, control and flexibility over how they can use their personal budget to take a break.

For the carer to access a Direct Payment, the same eligibility criteria applies as per the managed service.

The same principles also apply for carers as for any other service user who wish to receive their personal budget as a Direct Payment. The Direct Payment is paid directly to the carer (not the 'cared for').

A carer can also have the option of a Managed Budget and Direct Payment combined, as per any other service user. If a carer chooses to do this, the budget can be monitored in Mosaic, via 'Provisions' within 'Personal Budgets' section on the front screen of the carer's record.

Please see the attached link here for Direct Payments staff guidance for further information: [Direct Payments for Adults - Staff Guidance](#)

For carers that are registered with a Bassetlaw GP, NHS Short Breaks are only available to carers via a Direct Payment (see point 4. Eligibility Criteria above for more details).